

@aiwithcasti

The Elements That Make a 10K Website

Cursor effects · Menu effects · Infinite carousels
Micro-interactions · Typography systems · AI workflows

A practical reference — not a guru PDF. Real code, real tools, real output.

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Cursor Effects

A custom cursor is the first thing visitors notice — it signals craft. Here's what agencies build and how you replicate it with AI.

Types of cursor effects

Magnetic cursor — The cursor snaps and pulls toward interactive elements (buttons, links). Creates a tactile feel.

Trail / blob cursor — A glowing or fluid shape follows the pointer with a slight lag. Common on creative agencies.

Spotlight cursor — Dark background with a circle of light following the cursor. Great for portfolio or landing pages.

Custom SVG cursor — Replace the default arrow entirely with a branded icon or dot.

CSS — Spotlight cursor (paste into your globals.css)

```
body { cursor: none; }

.cursor {
  position: fixed; pointer-events: none; z-index: 9999;
  width: 24px; height: 24px; border-radius: 50%;
  background: rgba(123,94,167,0.6);
  transform: translate(-50%, -50%);
  transition: transform 0.1s ease, width 0.2s, height 0.2s;
}
```

JS — Attach cursor movement

```
const cursor = document.querySelector('.cursor');
document.addEventListener('mousemove', e => {
  cursor.style.left = e.clientX + 'px';
  cursor.style.top = e.clientY + 'px';
});
// Hover effect on buttons
document.querySelectorAll('a,button').forEach(el => {
  el.addEventListener('mouseenter', () => {
    cursor.style.transform = 'translate(-50%,-50%) scale(2)';
  });
  el.addEventListener('mouseleave', () => {
    cursor.style.transform = 'translate(-50%,-50%) scale(1)';
  });
});
```

■ PRO TIP

Prompt Cursor AI: 'Add a magnetic cursor effect to all .btn elements using GSAP'

Menu Effects

Navigation is visited on every page. A premium menu is one of the highest-ROI design decisions you'll make.

Fullscreen overlay menu

Menu opens full screen with staggered text animations. Used by luxury and creative brands.

Slide-in drawer

Panel slides in from left or right. Works on desktop and mobile. Clean and practical.

Mega menu with hover preview

Hovering a nav item reveals a rich panel with images and descriptions.

Sticky + hide-on-scroll

Navbar hides on scroll down, reappears on scroll up. Saves vertical space.

Fullscreen menu — core structure

HTML skeleton

```
<nav class='nav'>
  <button class='menu-toggle'>Menu</button>
  <div class='menu-overlay'>
    <ul class='menu-links'>
      <li><a href='/'>Home</a></li>
      <li><a href='/work'>Work</a></li>
      <li><a href='/contact'>Contact</a></li>
    </ul>
  </div>
</nav>
```

■ PRO TIP

Ask Cursor AI: 'Animate the menu links with a stagger effect using Framer Motion'

Infinite Carousel

Also called a marquee or ticker. Shows logos, testimonials, or service tags in a seamless, auto-scrolling loop. Zero JS required with CSS alone.

HTML — duplicate the track for seamless loop

```
<div class='marquee'>
  <div class='track'>
    <span>Webflow</span><span>Framer</span><span>Next.js</span>
    <!-- Duplicate items for seamless loop -->
    <span>Webflow</span><span>Framer</span><span>Next.js</span>
  </div>
</div>
```

CSS — pure CSS infinite scroll

```
.marquee { overflow: hidden; white-space: nowrap; }

.track {
  display: inline-flex; gap: 48px;
  animation: scroll 20s linear infinite;
}

@keyframes scroll {
  from { transform: translateX(0); }
  to   { transform: translateX(-50%); }
}

/* Pause on hover */
.marquee:hover .track { animation-play-state: paused; }
```

Variations to try

- Reverse direction (right → left vs left → right) for visual tension.
- Two rows scrolling in opposite directions (logo wall effect).
- Image cards instead of text — client logos, project thumbnails.
- Slow scroll for testimonials, fast for tech stack logos.

■ PRO TIP

Prompt: 'Create a vertical infinite carousel of testimonial cards with pause on hover'

Micro-Interactions

These are the tiny animations that make users feel the interface is alive. They're also what clients can never name — but always notice.

Button hover state

Scale up slightly + shadow deepens + color shifts.
Takes 3 CSS lines.

Form input focus ring

Input glows with brand color on focus. Feels custom and intentional.

Loading skeleton

Gray animated bars while content loads. Signals quality, reduces perceived wait.

Scroll-triggered reveal

Elements fade in as they enter viewport. Used on every premium site.

Like / toggle animation

Button morphs state with a spring animation. Keep it under 300ms.

Toast notifications

Small slide-in message confirms user action. Reassures and guides.

CSS — Scroll-triggered reveal (add class via IntersectionObserver)

```
.reveal {
  opacity: 0;
  transform: translateY(28px);
  transition: opacity 0.6s ease, transform 0.6s ease;
}
.reveal.visible {
  opacity: 1;
  transform: translateY(0);
}
```

JS — IntersectionObserver to trigger reveal

```
const observer = new IntersectionObserver(entries => {
  entries.forEach(e => {
    if (e.isIntersecting) {
      e.target.classList.add('visible');
      observer.unobserve(e.target); // fire once
    }
  });
}, { threshold: 0.15 });

document.querySelectorAll('.reveal')
  .forEach(el => observer.observe(el));
```

Typography System

Bad typography is the #1 thing that makes a site look cheap. A proper scale + pairing makes it look like it cost twice what it did.

Font pairing formula that works

Display (headlines): Clash Display, Syne, PP Editorial — makes a statement

Body (reading): Inter, Plus Jakarta Sans, DM Sans — clean and legible

Mono (code / tags): JetBrains Mono, Geist Mono — signals technical credibility

CSS — Fluid type scale (no media queries needed)

```
:root {
  --text-sm: clamp(0.8rem, 1.5vw, 0.9rem);
  --text-base: clamp(1rem, 2vw, 1.1rem);
  --text-lg: clamp(1.2rem, 2.5vw, 1.4rem);
  --text-xl: clamp(1.5rem, 3vw, 2rem);
  --text-2xl: clamp(2rem, 5vw, 3.5rem);
  --text-3xl: clamp(2.5rem, 7vw, 5rem);
}

h1 { font-size: var(--text-3xl); line-height: 1.1; }
h2 { font-size: var(--text-2xl); line-height: 1.2; }
p { font-size: var(--text-base); line-height: 1.7; }
```

■ PRO TIP

Load fonts via [Fontshare.com](https://fontshare.com) or [Bunny Fonts](https://bunnyfonts.com) — free, fast, and privacy-friendly.

AI Workflow with Cursor

Cursor is an AI-native code editor. Used right, you can go from blank project to deployed site in a single session.

The 5-step AI build loop

1. Cmd+K → 'Create a Next.js app with Tailwind and shadcn/ui'

Scaffold

2. **Layout** Cmd+K on the file → 'Add a sticky navbar + hero section with CTA button'

3. **Effects** Select a component → Cmd+K → 'Add a scroll-triggered fade-in using Framer Motion'

4. **Polish** Ask: 'Review this CSS for spacing inconsistencies and fix them'

5. **Deploy** Push to GitHub → connect to Vercel → live in 2 minutes

Useful Cursor AI prompts

- "Build an infinite horizontal logo scroll with pause-on-hover using pure CSS"
- "Add a fullscreen overlay menu with GSAP stagger animation on the links"
- "Refactor this component to add a magnetic hover effect on the button"
- "Make all section titles use a fluid clamp() type scale"
- "Add skeleton loading state to this card grid component"

10K Site Checklist

Every element on this list is present on sites that sell for \$10K+. Use it as your QA before any delivery.

Visual Polish

- Custom cursor (not default arrow)
- Consistent spacing system (8px grid)
- Fluid typography with clamp()
- At least 2 scroll-triggered reveals
- Hover states on every interactive element

Navigation

- Animated menu (overlay or drawer)
- Sticky / hide-on-scroll header
- Active state on nav links
- Mobile hamburger with smooth open/close

Motion & Feel

- Page transition (fade or slide between routes)
- Infinite carousel for social proof / logos
- At least 1 micro-interaction on a CTA button
- Smooth scrolling enabled (scroll-behavior: smooth)

Performance & Trust

- Images lazy-loaded and compressed (WebP)
- Core Web Vitals: LCP < 2.5s
- Meta tags, OG image for social sharing
- Privacy-friendly analytics (Plausible / Fathom)
- 404 page with navigation back



BONUS

Shape Blur Effect

A soft, glowing blurred shape that follows the cursor or sits behind content. Used heavily on AI / SaaS landing pages right now — it adds depth without needing any imagery.

Two ways to use it

Static ambient glow — A blurred gradient blob sits behind your hero text, fixed in place. Adds atmosphere instantly.

Cursor-reactive blur — The blurred shape follows the mouse with a delay/lag, like a soft spotlight made of color instead of light.

HTML — the blob

```
<div class='blur-shape'></div>
```

CSS — static glow version

```
.blur-shape {  
  position: absolute;  
  width: 420px; height: 420px;  
  background: radial-gradient(circle,  
    rgba(123,94,167,0.55), transparent 70%);  
  filter: blur(60px);  
  border-radius: 50%;  
  pointer-events: none;  
  z-index: 0;  
}
```

CSS — cursor-reactive version (position set via JS)

```
.blur-shape.follow {  
  position: fixed;  
  top: 0; left: 0;  
  transition: transform 0.3s ease-out;  
}
```

JS — make it follow the cursor with a lag

```
const blob = document.querySelector('.blur-shape');
let mouseX = 0, mouseY = 0, x = 0, y = 0;

document.addEventListener('mousemove', e => {
  mouseX = e.clientX; mouseY = e.clientY;
});

function animate() {
  x += (mouseX - x) * 0.08; // lag factor
  y += (mouseY - y) * 0.08;
  blob.style.transform =
    `translate(${x - 210}px, ${y - 210}px)`;
  requestAnimationFrame(animate);
}
animate();
```

■ PRO TIP

Prompt Cursor AI: 'Add a blurred radial gradient shape that follows the cursor with a smooth lag, placed behind the hero content'

Notes

- Lower the lag factor (0.08 → 0.04) for a slower, dreamier trail.
- Use 2-3 overlapping blobs with different colors for a richer effect.
- Keep z-index below your text/content so it stays in the background.
- On mobile, disable cursor-follow (no mouse) and keep it static.

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Follow for more AI + web build breakdowns.

Made with Cursor AI
Deployed on Vercel